

Western esotericism (the very term dates from the nineteenth century) is an etic construct applied retrospectively to earlier periods, and the fact that specific components are nowadays seen as belonging to it does not mean they were necessarily seen as “other” in earlier periods; quite frequently the opposite was true, and the process of marginalization and exclusion occurred only later [...]. Among the various examples that could be given, astrology is an obvious one.⁴¹

This can easily be combined with my own interpretation: European cultural history is characterized by a dialectic of rejection and fascination vis-à-vis those currents that modern scholars regard as belonging to esotericism. What can be dubbed the ‘processes of distancing’ is a discursive event that took place during the past 200–300 years. Analyzed with the instruments of discourse theory, what Hanegraaff describes is actually a discursive formation, i.e. the concretization of discourses in institutions, such as the university and its specific research programs.

I will return to this discussion in chapter 10. At this point, I want to introduce my own attempt to conceptualize the study of esoteric discourse in Western culture. I will start with a reassessment of the concept of secrecy.

Secrecy as Social Capital

As noted above, the concept of secrecy is a delicate one in the study of Western esotericism. In an attempt to establish the serious study of Western esotericism in an academic context, representatives of this young field of research have explicitly distinguished esotericism from secrecy. This is because, as Antoine Faivre writes in the *Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism*, the

notion of secrecy is often associated with that of esotericism, even to the point of reducing the sense of this latter term to that of the former. The typological meaning of “esotericism” as referring to secrecy should, however, be clearly distinguished from the historical meaning used in the present reference work and increasingly in general academic parlance.⁴²

⁴¹ Hanegraaff, “The Trouble with Images,” 110 note 12.

⁴² Faivre, “Secrecy III,” 1056; see also *idem*, “Notions of Concealment and Secrecy”; cf. Laurant, “Du secret ésotérique.”

Similarly, Wouter J. Hanegraaff notes that “emphases on secrecy and interiority can certainly be found within quite a few of the historical currents [of esotericism], but they are absent in many others, and therefore cannot be seen as defining characteristics.”⁴³ Although it is useful to distinguish theoretically between esotericism and secrecy—even if not only lay people but many scholars, too, simply neglect such a distinction—the emphasis on this difference has led to a certain disregard of secrecy in the academic study of esotericism. Therefore, let me attempt to determine the place of secrecy within esoteric discourses, without identifying the one with the other.

The concept of secrecy has been quite influential both in sociology and in the academic study of religion. As early as 1906 Georg Simmel devoted an article to “The Sociology of Secrecy and of Secret Societies.” In this famous text, Simmel argues that secrecy

secures, so to speak, the possibility of a second world alongside of the obvious world, and the latter is most strenuously affected by the former. Every relationship between two individuals or two groups will be characterized by the ratio of secrecy that is involved in it. Even when one of the parties does not notice the secret factor, yet the attitude of the concealer, and consequently the whole relationship, will be modified by it. The historical development of society is in many respects characterized by the fact that what was formerly public passes under the protection of secrecy, and that, on the contrary, what was formerly secret ceases to require such protection and proclaims itself.⁴⁴

Simmel regards secrecy as “a universal sociological form, which, as such, has nothing to do with the moral valuations of its contents.”⁴⁵ It is the social structure or form, not the content that defines the *function* of secrecy in communicational processes. Even if secrecy is a social function in all of human communication, it certainly plays an even more important role in secret societies. Simmel explains:

The structure of the group is often with the direct view to assurance of keeping certain subjects from general knowledge. This is the case with those peculiar types of secret society whose substance is an esoteric doctrine, a theoretical, mystical, religious gnosis. In this case secrecy is the sociological end-unto-itself.⁴⁶

⁴³ Hanegraaff, “Esotericism,” 338.

⁴⁴ Simmel, “Sociology of Secrecy,” 462–463.

⁴⁵ *Ibid.*, 463.

⁴⁶ *Ibid.*, 476–477.

Scholars of esotericism have further elaborated on this idea and focused on the various paradoxes involved in secretive discourses. For instance, it can be argued that *every* notion of a ‘secret tradition,’ so common in esotericism, is a *contradictio in adjecto* because either it is secret—in which case it cannot be a tradition—or it is a tradition—and thus it cannot be a secret. Calling this the “double bind” problem of secrecy, Hugh B. Urban concludes:

Secrecy [...] is better understood, not in terms of its content or substance—which is ultimately unknowable, if there even is one—but rather in terms of its *forms* or *strategies*—the tactics by which social agents conceal or reveal, hoard or exchange, certain valued information. In this sense, secrecy is a discursive strategy that transforms a given piece of knowledge into a scarce and precious resource, a valuable commodity, the possession of which in turn bestows status, prestige, or symbolic capital on its owner.⁴⁷

With his application of Pierre Bourdieu’s concept of symbolic capital Urban hits the right key, as I will elaborate later. As scholars we have to focus less on the content of secret knowledge but on the very fact that this knowledge is claimed.

Claims of superior or perfect knowledge are thus often intrinsically linked to a discourse of *secrecy*, but not because esoteric truths are restricted to an ‘inner circle’ of specialists or initiates, but because the dialectic of concealment and revelation is a structural element of secretive discourses. Esoteric knowledge is not so much secret, but *hidden*. Elliot R. Wolfson notes with regard to kabbalah:

The hermeneutic of esotericism displayed in many kabbalistic sources does attest to the elitist posture based on the presumption that secrets must not be divulged to those unworthy to receive them, but it certainly goes beyond it as well, inasmuch as the concealment of the secret is dialectically related to its disclosure. Simply put, the utterance of the mystery is possible because of the inherent impossibility of its being uttered. [...] Alternatively expressed, the duplicitous nature of secrecy is such that in order to be a secret, the secret cannot be disclosed as the secret

⁴⁷ Urban, “Torment of Secrecy,” 210. See also Urban’s compelling analysis of the function of secrecy in the politics of the Bush administration (Urban, *Secrets of the Kingdom*). An earlier study of this topic, linked to esotericism, is Urban, “Religion and Secrecy in the Bush Administration.”

it purports to be, but if the secret is not disclosed as the secret it secretly cannot be, it cannot be the secret it exposes itself not to be.⁴⁸

Theoretically, the revelation of esoteric truths is accessible to anyone who follows the prescribed ways and strategies that lead to perfect knowledge, even if the requirements of following these strategies are so high that an elitist self-understanding emerges from them. But we may add another dimension to secretive discourses. It is not necessarily the case that no one else knows the content of the secret but that people simply do not tell, except at the proper juncture of transmission. From this point of view, the chief effects of secrecy are on the recipients of the secret, not on those from whom it is putatively withheld. The social capital of a secret is attractive for people outside the group only if the fact is known that there is a secret to be told.

We can base this interpretation on Georg Simmel who more than one hundred years ago wrote:

Secrecy involves a tension which, at the moment of revelation, finds its release. This constitutes the climax in the development of the secret; in it the whole charm of secrecy concentrates and rises to its highest pitch [...]. Secrecy also is sustained by the consciousness that it *might be* exploited, and therefore confers power to modify fortunes, to produce surprises, joys, and calamities, even if the latter be only misfortunes to ourselves.⁴⁹

With Simmel's notion of *power*, we have arrived at what in the second half of the twentieth century became known as discourse analysis. Above, I have already engaged the post-structuralist tradition in cultural analysis and argued that the concepts of *discourse* and *field*, developed by Michel Foucault and Pierre Bourdieu, are particularly helpful to understand the dynamics of religious polemics and pluralities of knowledge. With regard to the mechanisms of secrecy and concealment that characterize esoteric discourse, we should add Bourdieu's concept of *capital* to our analytical instruments.

⁴⁸ Wolfson, "Kabbalah," 1052. Cf. also Michael Taussig's comment: "The real skill of the practitioner lies not in skilled concealment but in the skilled revelation of skilled concealment. Magic is efficacious not despite the trick but on account of its exposure. The mystery is heightened, not dissipated, by unmasking and in various ways, direct and oblique, ritual serves as a stage for so many unmaskings. Hence power flows not from masking but from unmasking, which masks more than masking" ("Viscerality, Faith, and Skepticism," 273).

⁴⁹ Simmel, "Sociology of Secrecy," 465–466, italics original.

If power relations form an identifiable structure, various forms of capital come into play and regulate access to resources and social status. Bourdieu differentiates four categories of “goods”: (1) economic capital; (2) social capital (i.e. various kinds of valued relations with others);⁵⁰ (3) cultural capital (i.e. primarily legitimate knowledge of one kind or another); (4) symbolic capital (i.e. prestige and social honor). Despite the theoretical distinction between various forms of capital, Bourdieu makes it clear that all forms of capital can be turned into economic capital, and that a number of further interrelations between forms of capital are at work. And Bourdieu also notes that *practice* is the sum product of an agent’s active engagement with capital in a given field: “[(habitus) (capital)] + field = practice.”⁵¹

The nature of positions, their “objective definition,” is to be found in their relationship to the relevant form of capital. What is more, a field can be ‘self-sustaining,’ because the existence of a field *presupposes* and, when it is actively functioning, *creates* a belief among agents in the legitimacy and value of the capital which is at stake in the field. This legitimate *interest* in the field is produced by the same historical processes that have produced the field itself.

Equipped with the methodological tools provided by Pierre Bourdieu we can now return to the relationship between esoteric discourses and secrecy. It is a common feature of many discrete societies that members enjoy access to superior, exclusive, and elitist knowledge, which means an increase of social, cultural, and symbolic capital. Time and again, esoteric fields have been formed as a result of historical processes, leading to an interest of agents (i.e. persons acting in the field) in the disclosure of secret knowledge; in their functioning, these fields at the same time created the belief in the legitimacy and the importance of participating in these forms of capital.

As we have seen in the previous chapter, the notion of ‘tradition’ plays a significant role here. By adhering to a claimed secret line of wisdom, intellectuals from the Middle Ages through today have claimed superior knowledge and thus increased their social, cultural, and symbolic capital. Consequently, the notions of *prisca theologia* and *philosophia perennis* have served as identity markers in an esoteric discourse that is characterized by a dialectic of concealment and disclosure. This

⁵⁰ Social capital refers to all resources that an agent can mobilize and profit from, because the agent is involved in a network of relationships with others.

⁵¹ Bourdieu, *Distinction*, 101.